



IN JUST ONE YEAR, ARJUN HAS GAINED NEARLY 90 RATING POINTS, A LEAP THAT IS ROOTED IN HIS DARING APPROACH

Standing out: While Arjun may not be the most talked-about Indian prodigy compared to R. Praggnanandhaa and D. Gukesh, who often shine in high-stakes tournaments, he has carved his own path. LENNART OOTES / FIDE

the first six rounds and still faced strong opposition," he says. "Of course, I was disappointed at the time, but afterwards, I viewed it as a chance to learn from my mistakes. My coach and I worked on the areas I struggled with, and that definitely helped.

Playing stronger opponents is always beneficial, no matter your level. Even at 2750, playing more games against top players like Magnus is valuable. In hindsight, it was actually a good decision to play there," he shares.

Arjun also sees his friend and compatriot Gukesh, who became the youngest World Championship challenger at 17, as a clear favourite against China's Ding Liren.

He says, "Gukesh did have a shaky event at the European Club Cup, and

I heard Magnus mention that this might give Ding some confidence. But I still think Gukesh is clearly the favourite. Ding seems low on confidence, and during the Olympiad, I noticed he wasn't physically well — something to do with his breathing — he seemed uncomfortable, and that was even after he had improved. I do feel sorry for him that he has to go through all these challenges and still has to play in such a prestigious match.

But this is sport, and regardless of the outcome, even if he wins or loses, I hope Ding recovers fully, both physically and mentally."

Beyond chess, Arjun is a Tollywood enthusiast and a fan of Junior NTR's work. When not honing his skills on the board, he enjoys playing table tennis. Family support has been a cornerstone of his journey, and he

credits them for being his constant strength. "My parents and my sister have always been supportive. My mother travelled with me often, making her support very visible, but my dad's hard work behind the scenes allowed me to pursue chess without worrying about finances, even when I had no sponsorship. My sister has always been there to motivate me," he shares.

"After the World Cup last year, moving on was really challenging, but my family's support made it possible. Without a strong support system, overcoming these sorts of setbacks can even take years," he says.

Much like General Patton's boldness, Arjun's style on the chessboard is cementing his reputation as one of the most formidable, if not the most colourful, players in modern chess.